comparing notes and filling in the blanks. Arwind was most thorough in his approach, like a typical Gorkha (he was in the Gorkha Regiment) and pointed me towards several topics I had either overlooked or not gone into in sufficient detail. While we were busy studying, his wife Anita and daughter Aarti, who was the same age as Isha, would give company to Isha, and the two girls became close friends. Both of us cleared the entrance exam and were neighbours at Wellington during the course too.

Before Col Dhariwal left for Sri Lanka, we invited him and Mrs Dhariwal over for dinner, along with a few other Regimental officers who happened to be in town. Col Dhariwal, 'Subba' to his friends, was a jovial Sikh officer, who I think was a bit surprised at having got command of a Battalion. We talked about the situation in Sri Lanka and the Battalion's duties in Trincomalee, and I gave him a first-hand account of the state of affairs. All the while, Isha was sticking to my knee, not going to anyone, not even to the other ladies present. During a lull in the conversation, Subba called out for Isha and she happily trotted off to him, much to everyone's surprise. That made Col Dhariwal's day; he was so happy at having achieved what no other could, and probably put me in his good books too. Having spent time in the Regimental Centre among Sikh troops probably had something to do with that.

My stay in Gwalior was short-lived as the DSSC exam results were announced, and once again to everyone's surprise, I had passed in the first attempt. I would have to join the DSCC 47 commencing April 1991. We were expecting our second child by then, so Veena was once again with her parents in Delhi. They had shifted to Vasant Kunj by then, a newly constructed DDA colony in which my father-in-law had been allotted a flat in a draw of lots. Vasant Kunj was then at the back of beyond and what is today a six-lane Nelson Mandela Marg,

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